

DAY 34 — MARKETING DETECTIVE

Campaign investigation companion worksheet · 10 fictional cases

How to use this PDF

Use the interactive HTML for the detective-game experience. This PDF is the printable companion: review each case, inspect the evidence, make your own diagnosis, then compare it with the explanation and suggested improvements.

Case 1: Northstar Coffee

Industry: Specialty Coffee **Difficulty:** Medium

Campaign objective: Increase online subscriptions among busy urban professionals.

Target audience: Urban professionals aged 24–40 who already drink premium coffee.

Budget allocation: Instagram: █45,000 · Google: █25,000 · Email: █10,000 · Influencers: █20,000

Metric	Value
Reach	620K
Ctr	0.8%
Engagement	7.9%
Conversions	1.1%
Sales	█3.2L

Customer comments: The photos looked great, but I couldn't tell what made the subscription different. | I kept seeing lifestyle posts but never saw a clear reason to subscribe.

Social media performance: Instagram generated strong saves and comments, but most conversations focused on aesthetics rather than subscription benefits.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign optimized for lifestyle engagement instead of clearly communicating the subscription value proposition.

Three supporting clues: Instagram produced high engagement but very low click-through. | The subscription offer was rarely explained in the creative. | Customers praised the visuals but could not identify a clear reason to subscribe.

Correct explanation: The campaign attracted attention but failed to convert that attention into understanding and action. The creative emphasized premium lifestyle imagery more than the subscription benefit.

Suggested improvements:

Case 2: PulseFit

Industry: Fitness Technology **Difficulty:** Hard

Campaign objective: Generate paid trial sign-ups for a new AI fitness app.

Target audience: Beginners aged 18–35 interested in convenient home workouts.

Budget allocation: TikTok: █70,000 · Reels: █50,000 · YouTube: █30,000 · Creators: █50,000

Metric	Value
Reach	1.8M
Ctr	3.4%
Engagement	11.8%

Conversions	0.4%
Sales	■1.1L

Customer comments: The videos made the app look intense. | I thought it was only for serious athletes.

Social media performance: Short-form videos achieved exceptional reach and engagement, but comments repeatedly described the product as intimidating.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign's creative did not match the beginner audience it was targeting.

Three supporting clues: Reach and engagement were extremely high. | Conversion rate remained below 1%. | Audience comments repeatedly described the workouts as intimidating.

Correct explanation: The campaign captured attention but communicated the wrong identity. Beginners saw advanced-looking workouts and concluded that the product was not designed for them.

Suggested improvements:

Case 3: EcoNest

Industry: Home Products **Difficulty:** Medium

Campaign objective: Increase sales of reusable household products.

Target audience: Environmentally conscious families aged 28–50.

Budget allocation: Facebook: ■40,000 · Pinterest: ■25,000 · Email: ■15,000 · Search: ■20,000

Metric	Value
Reach	480K
Ctr	2.9%
Engagement	6.2%
Conversions	0.5%
Sales	■1.6L

Customer comments: I liked the idea but the prices were hard to justify. | I wanted to know how much waste or money the products actually save.

Social media performance: Environmental conversations were positive, but product posts attracted questions about price and practical savings.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign communicated environmental ideals without proving the practical economic value of the products.

Three supporting clues: Engagement centered on environmental values rather than product benefits. | Customers repeatedly questioned the price. | Conversion remained low despite healthy click-through.

Correct explanation: The audience agreed with the mission but needed a stronger reason to buy. The campaign created values-based interest without closing the gap between values and purchase justification.

Suggested improvements:

Case 4: ByteBox

Industry: Consumer Electronics Difficulty: Hard

Campaign objective: Launch budget wireless earbuds among college students.

Target audience: College students looking for affordable everyday audio.

Budget allocation: Instagram: █80,000 · Creators: █90,000 · Search: █30,000 · Email: █5,000

Metric	Value
Reach	950K
Ctr	2.1%
Engagement	8.6%
Conversions	0.7%
Sales	█2.4L

Customer comments: I couldn't tell whether they were actually affordable. | The discount information was buried.

Social media performance: Creator content looked polished but did not communicate the low-price advantage clearly.

Primary marketing mistake: Premium-looking creative buried the campaign's strongest competitive advantage: affordability.

Three supporting clues: The product was positioned visually like a luxury device. | Discount information appeared late. | Students mentioned uncertainty about price despite the low-cost offer.

Correct explanation: Creative positioning contradicted the intended value proposition. Instead of making affordability obvious, the campaign made the product appear more expensive than it was.

Suggested improvements:

Case 5: FreshFork

Industry: Food Delivery Difficulty: Easy

Campaign objective: Increase weekday lunch orders from office workers.

Target audience: Office workers ordering lunch between 12 PM and 2 PM.

Budget allocation: Instagram: █30,000 · Search: █55,000 · Push: █15,000 · Creators: █10,000

Metric	Value
Reach	370K
Ctr	4.2%
Engagement	4.7%
Conversions	0.9%
Sales	█2.0L

Customer comments: The ads looked nice but I saw them at night. | I needed a reminder around lunchtime.

Social media performance: Instagram impressions were spread across evenings and weekends even though the offer was designed for lunch.

Primary marketing mistake: Campaign timing did not align with the audience's lunch decision window.

Three supporting clues: Many social impressions happened outside lunch hours. | Customers requested lunchtime reminders. | Search performed better because users were already looking for food.

Correct explanation: The offer was relevant, but the campaign reached people at the wrong moment. Timing is part of targeting for products tied to predictable routines.

Suggested improvements:

Case 6: LumaSkin

Industry: Beauty Difficulty: Medium

Campaign objective: Generate first purchases for a new sensitive-skin moisturizer.

Target audience: Adults aged 22–45 with sensitive or reactive skin.

Budget allocation: TikTok: █65,000 · Instagram: █45,000 · Creators: █90,000 · Search: █10,000

Metric	Value
Reach	1.2M
Ctr	2.8%
Engagement	12.4%
Conversions	0.3%
Sales	█90000

Customer comments: Every creator had perfect skin, so it felt unrealistic. | I wanted to see real sensitive-skin experiences.

Social media performance: Creator engagement was high, but comments questioned authenticity and relevance to sensitive skin.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign used polished beauty influencers without enough credibility or representation for the specific problem.

Three supporting clues: Engagement was high while purchase conversion was extremely low. | Comments questioned creator authenticity. | The target audience's specific skin concern was barely demonstrated.

Correct explanation: Influencer reach created awareness but not trust. For a sensitive-skin product, believable experience and problem-specific credibility matter more than polished imagery.

Suggested improvements:

Case 7: StudySprint

Industry: Education Difficulty: Easy

Campaign objective: Increase paid subscriptions for an exam-preparation platform.

Target audience: University students preparing for competitive exams.

Budget allocation: YouTube: █60,000 · Search: █60,000 · Telegram: █20,000 · Creators: █30,000

Metric	Value
Reach	710K
Ctr	5.1%
Engagement	9.3%
Conversions	2.6%
Sales	█4.8L

Customer comments: The free mock test convinced me. | I liked seeing actual score improvements.

Social media performance: Educational demonstrations and free mock tests consistently outperformed generic promotional videos.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign initially underinvested in proof-based educational content despite strong conversion signals.

Three supporting clues: Free mock-test content had the highest conversion rate. | Generic promotional videos generated lower-quality traffic. | Students mentioned proof of improvement as a reason to purchase.

Correct explanation: The campaign had a strong message but initially underinvested in proof-based content. Demonstrated learning improvement was the strongest marketing asset.

Suggested improvements:

Case 8: UrbanRide

Industry: Mobility Difficulty: Hard

Campaign objective: Increase weekday app usage among commuters.

Target audience: Daily commuters traveling 5–20 km in major cities.

Budget allocation: Meta: █70,000 · Search: █40,000 · Outdoor: █120,000 · Referral: █20,000

Metric	Value
Reach	2.4M
Ctr	1.2%
Engagement	3.1%
Conversions	0.5%
Sales	█2.7L

Customer comments: I saw the billboards everywhere but didn't know the offer. | I only remembered the logo.

Social media performance: Brand recall increased, but the promotional offer was poorly remembered.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign spent heavily on awareness media without giving commuters a memorable immediate reason to take the first ride.

Three supporting clues: Outdoor advertising received the largest budget allocation. | Customers remembered the brand but not the offer. | Conversion remained low despite very high reach.

Correct explanation: The campaign built visibility but failed to connect awareness with a clear action. Commuters needed a simple first-ride incentive and clear instructions.

Suggested improvements:

Case 9: GreenByte Cloud

Industry: B2B Software **Difficulty:** Hard

Campaign objective: Generate qualified leads for cloud cost-optimization software.

Target audience: CFOs, CTOs and engineering leaders at mid-sized companies.

Budget allocation: LinkedIn: █120,000 · Webinars: █70,000 · Email: █30,000 · Search: █80,000

Metric	Value
Reach	260K
Ctr	1.9%
Engagement	4.1%
Conversions	0.6%
Sales	█6.2L

Customer comments: The ads were too technical for executives. | I needed to understand the financial impact. | The webinar was useful once ROI examples appeared.

Social media performance: Technical posts generated modest engagement while ROI-focused webinar clips generated stronger lead quality.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign communicated technical capabilities instead of translating them into executive-level financial outcomes.

Three supporting clues: Executive comments repeatedly asked about ROI. | Technical content produced weaker lead quality. | ROI-focused webinar content produced better-qualified leads.

Correct explanation: Executives needed business outcomes rather than implementation details. The message did not match the information needs of the decision-makers.

Suggested improvements:

Case 10: PetalHome

Industry: Home Decor **Difficulty:** Medium

Campaign objective: Increase online sales of affordable home decor collections.

Target audience: First-time renters and young homeowners aged 23–38.

Budget allocation: Pinterest: █50,000 · Instagram: █60,000 · Email: █15,000 · Influencers: █75,000

Metric	Value
Reach	890K
Ctr	3.8%
Engagement	10.2%
Conversions	0.8%
Sales	█2.9L

Customer comments: The rooms looked beautiful but expensive. | I didn't know the products were affordable. | The influencer homes were too perfect to copy.

Social media performance: Highly styled interiors produced strong saves but weak purchase intent.

Primary marketing mistake: The campaign showed aspirational interiors without demonstrating that the same look was achievable within the audience's budget.

Three supporting clues: Content had strong saves but weak conversion. | Customers perceived the products as expensive. | Influencer content featured unrealistic high-end rooms.

Correct explanation: The campaign created aspiration but not attainability. The audience needed to see how affordable products could recreate the look in ordinary homes.

Suggested improvements:

Detective Reflection

After completing the cases, write down the marketing patterns you noticed.

1. What type of mistake appeared most often?

2. Which metric did you find most useful for diagnosing a campaign?

3. When can high engagement be misleading?

4. How can customer comments reveal a targeting or positioning problem?

5. What is one marketing habit you will use in future campaign analysis?
